Democracy, Authoritarianism and Immigration

39 key historical facts stated in Jeff Kisling's blog posts on this topic, each checked against an outside source.

Democracy, Authoritarianism and Immigration

These posts follow U.S. immigration enforcement and civil liberties from the 2016 election through the federal enforcement surge in Minneapolis in early 2026. They cover the 2017 travel ban, the 2018 family separation policy, ICE detention and Iowa's ties to it, DACA, and the January 6, 2021 Capitol attack. They also cover 2025 executive actions against campus protesters and student visa holders, the June 2025 National Guard deployment in Los Angeles, and Iowa's 2018 critical-infrastructure protest law.

39 facts checked against outside sources, 6 of them corrected (the posts had a detail slightly wrong; the corrected version is shown). Each fact lists the source that confirms it and the posts that state it. The wording is a plain summary, not a quotation from the posts.

Facts

1. 2011-10–2016-12 (corrected)

About 18,000 Syrian refugees (18,007) were resettled in the United States between October 1, 2011 and December 31, 2016.

> ***Correction:*** *Posts give the period as 2011–2019; the source figure runs to the end of 2016, and resettlement continued at lower levels afterward.*

- **Source:** Syrian Refugees in the United States (Migration Policy Institute)
- **In the posts:** Special Envoy of the U.N. High Commissioner for Refugees (2019-08-01)

2. 2016

Russia's Internet Research Agency ran a social media influence campaign around the 2016 U.S. election using fake American personas and bot networks; the Special Counsel's report (2019) noted Facebook's estimate that IRA content reached about 126 million people.

- **Source:** What the Mueller Report Tells Us About Russian Influence Operations (Lawfare)
- **In the posts:** Weaponized AI Propaganda Machine (2017-04-22)

3. 2016-10-03

On October 3, 2016, the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Seventh Circuit upheld a lower-court order blocking Indiana Governor Mike Pence's attempt to stop the resettlement of Syrian refugees in the state, finding the policy discriminated by nationality.

- **Source:** Federal Appeals Court Rejects Indiana's Efforts to Block Syrian Refugee Resettlement (ACLU)
- **In the posts:** Indiana Under Pence (2016-10-05)

4. 2016-11-08 (corrected)

Early estimates after the November 2016 election put turnout at about 55 percent of voting-age citizens, described as a 20-year low; later U.S. Elections Project estimates put turnout at about 58 percent of eligible voters, roughly equal to 2012.

> ***Correction:*** *Posts give 55.4% of eligible voters as a 20-year low; that was an early estimate based on the voting-age population, and final estimates of turnout among eligible voters were higher.*

- **Source:** Voter turnout at 20-year low in 2016 (WTVR CBS 6 (CNN Wire)); Turnout in the 2016 Presidential Election (FairVote)
- **In the posts:** Challenged on Democracy (2016-11-12)

5. 2016-11-08

In the November 8, 2016 presidential election Hillary Clinton won the national popular vote by nearly 2.9 million votes while Donald Trump won the Electoral College; she was the fifth candidate in U.S. history to win the popular vote and lose the presidency.

- **Source:** Clinton wins US popular vote by widest margin of any losing presidential candidate (Christian Science Monitor)
- **In the posts:** Challenged on Democracy (2016-11-12)

6. 2017-01-27

On January 27, 2017, President Trump issued the executive order "Protecting the Nation From Foreign Terrorist Entry Into the United States" (the first travel ban), suspending entry from seven Muslim-majority countries for 90 days and suspending all refugee admissions for 120 days, with Syrian refugees barred indefinitely.

- **Source:** Trump's executive order by the numbers (Atlantic Council)
- **In the posts:** Censure the President (2018-01-12); Reclaiming the Moral Narrative (2018-06-21); Language (2025-03-13)

7. 2018

ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations reported 158,581 administrative arrests in fiscal year 2018, including 138,117 people with criminal convictions or pending charges (up 10,125 from FY2017), and 256,085 removals.

- **Source:** Fiscal Year 2018 ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations Report (U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement); ERO 2018 (U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement)
- **In the posts:** Senator Chuck Grassley on Immigration (2019-04-12)

8. 2018-01-11

At a January 11, 2018 Oval Office meeting on immigration, President Trump reportedly disparaged Haiti and African nations with a vulgarity and suggested the U.S. should instead take immigrants from countries like Norway; the White House did not deny the remarks.

- **Source:** White House doesn't deny that President Trump referred to Haiti, African nations as 's---hole' countries (CNBC)
- **In the posts:** Censure the President (2018-01-12)

9. 2018-04

In 2018 Iowa enacted Senate File 2235, which created the crime of "critical infrastructure sabotage" (covering facilities such as pipelines and utilities) as a class B felony punishable by up to 25 years in prison and a fine of $85,000 to $100,000; Governor Kim Reynolds signed it in April 2018 and it took effect July 1, 2018.

> ***Note:*** *The law dates from the 2018 legislative session, not 2017.*

- **Source:** Senate File 2235 (enrolled text) (Iowa Legislature); Gov. Kim Reynolds signs "sabotage" bill into law (Bold Iowa); Legislative wrap-up for 2018 (Farm Progress)
- **In the posts:** Feeling Unfree (2018-01-27); Protest (2018-03-15); Indigenous Resistance to the Dakota Access Pipeline: Criminalization of dissent and suppression of protest (2018-04-09); Attempts to Silence Pipeline Protestors (2019-10-25)

10. 2018-04-06

On April 6, 2018, Attorney General Jeff Sessions issued a memorandum directing U.S. Attorneys on the Southwest border to prosecute all illegal-entry referrals (the "zero tolerance" policy), which led to parents being prosecuted and separated from their children.

- **Source:** DOJ announces zero tolerance policy on Southwest border (Immigration Policy Tracking Project); Trump administration family separation policy (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Senator Chuck Grassley on Immigration (2019-04-12); #Families Belong Together (2018-06-16); Where are the babies and children? (2018-07-12)

11. 2018-06-20

On June 20, 2018, President Trump signed Executive Order 13841, "Affording Congress an Opportunity to Address Family Separation," directing that families be detained together and asking the Attorney General to seek changes to the Flores settlement to allow longer family detention.

- **Source:** Executive Order 13841 directs families to be detained together and seeks modification of Flores settlement (Immigration Policy Tracking Project)
- **In the posts:** Reclaiming the Moral Narrative (2018-06-21); Senator Chuck Grassley on Immigration (2019-04-12)

12. 2018-06-25

On June 25, 2018, Customs and Border Protection Commissioner Kevin McAleenan said the agency would stop referring every parent who crossed the border with children for criminal prosecution.

- **Source:** Trump administration family separation policy (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Senator Chuck Grassley on Immigration (2019-04-12)

13. 2018-06-26

More than 5,500 children were separated from their parents under the Trump administration's 2017-2018 border policy; on June 26, 2018, U.S. District Judge Dana Sabraw ordered reunification within 30 days (14 days for children under five), noting the government had no system to track separated children.

- **Source:** Trump administration family separation policy (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Intentional Incompetence (2018-06-22); Where are the babies and children? (2018-07-12); Reclaiming the Moral Narrative (2018-06-21)

14. 2018-07-10

Under the court-enforced Flores settlement (1997, as interpreted in a 2015 order), migrant children generally may not be held in detention for more than 20 days; on July 10, 2018, Judge Dolly Gee rejected the Trump administration's request to detain children with their parents beyond that limit.

- **Source:** Judge Rejects Trump Administration's Bid To Detain Migrant Children Indefinitely (NPR (via WHYY))
- **In the posts:** Where are the babies and children? (2018-07-12)

15. 2019-07-12

On July 12, 2019, "Lights for Liberty" vigils against immigrant detention camps were held at more than 600 locations worldwide.

- **Source:** Lights for Liberty: Community unites outside T. Don Hutto Detention Camp for vigil and worldwide moment of silence (Grassroots Leadership)
- **In the posts:** Lights for Liberty (2019-07-13)

16. 2019-07-12

On July 12, 2019, Vice President Mike Pence toured a Border Patrol station in McAllen, Texas, where reporters saw nearly 400 men held in caged areas too crowded for all of them to lie down.

- **Source:** Pence Praises Border Patrol After Visit to Detention Centers in Texas (Mother Jones)
- **In the posts:** Lights for Liberty (2019-07-13)

17. 2019-08

Iowa businesses received about $73 million from contracts with ICE and Customs and Border Protection between fiscal years 2008 and 2019, most of it going to Rockwell Collins of Cedar Rapids, according to an August 2019 Iowa City Press-Citizen analysis of USASpending.gov data.

- **Source:** Critics call on Iowa companies to stop federal contracts tied to immigration enforcement (CBS2 Iowa)
- **In the posts:** Protest Against ICE in Iowa (2019-10-11)

18. 2019-11-12

The U.S. Supreme Court heard oral arguments on the Trump administration's rescission of DACA on November 12, 2019 (DHS v. Regents of the University of California); on June 18, 2020, it ruled 5-4 that the rescission was arbitrary and capricious.

- **Source:** Department of Homeland Security v. Regents of the University of California (Wikipedia)

- **In the posts:** Defend DACA Rally Today (2019-11-12)

19. 2020-07-01 (corrected)

After arrests at a July 1, 2020 racial-justice protest, the Iowa State Patrol banned several protesters from the State Capitol grounds; in December 2020 U.S. District Judge Rebecca Goodgame Ebinger blocked enforcement of the bans as likely unconstitutional, and in August 2021 the state settled, withdrawing the bans and paying $5,000 to each of five plaintiffs.

> ***Correction:*** *A 2021 post says the ban was 'later declared illegal'; the court issued a preliminary injunction finding the ban likely violated protesters' rights, and the case ended in a settlement rather than a final ruling.*

- **Source:** Judge OKs Iowa Capitol protesters' settlement, dismisses ban (CBS2 Iowa / Associated Press)
- **In the posts:** Racial justice protesters banned from Iowa Capitol in “stunning misuse of power” (2020-10-09); State of Intimidation (2021-08-26)

20. 2021-01-06

On January 6, 2021, supporters of President Trump stormed the U.S. Capitol to disrupt Congress's count of the 2020 Electoral College votes, delaying certification for several hours; the FBI estimated 2,000-2,500 people entered the building and more than 1,500 were later federally charged.

- **Source:** January 6 United States Capitol attack (Wikipedia); Jan. 6 Committee Releases Final Report - All 845 Pages (Mediaite)
- **In the posts:** Storming the Capitol (2021-01-07); Prepare for Change (2021-01-08); May these steps be steps of prayer (2021-08-27)

21. 2024-11-21

On November 21, 2024 the U.S. House passed H.R. 9495 by 219–184; the bill would let the Treasury Secretary designate nonprofits as 'terrorist supporting organizations' and strip their tax-exempt status.

> ***Note:*** *The sources seen do not mention H.R. 6408 by number.*

- **Source:** Why a newly passed House 'terrorism financing' bill could threaten nonprofits and free speech (Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists); House Passes Dystopian Bill Targeting Nonprofits (Hyperallergic)
- **In the posts:** Defend Dissent (2024-11-11)

22. 2025-01-20 (corrected)

On January 20, 2025, President Trump signed Executive Order 14161, "Protecting the United States from Foreign Terrorists and Other National Security and Public Safety Threats," requiring enhanced vetting of noncitizens and directing agencies to identify countries whose nationals' admission could be suspended.

> ***Correction:*** *The 2025-03-07 post quotes 'pro-jihadist protests' and 'Hamas sympathizers' as coming from this order; those phrases come from the White House fact sheet accompanying EO 14188 (January 29, 2025).*

- **Source:** EO: Protecting the United States from Foreign Terrorists and Other National Security and Public Safety Threats (Immigration Policy Tracking Project)
- **In the posts:** Using AI to repress dissent (2025-03-07)

23. 2025-01-29

On January 29, 2025, President Trump signed Executive Order 14188, "Additional Measures to Combat Anti-Semitism"; the White House fact sheet told "resident aliens who joined in the pro-jihadist protests" that "we will find you, and we will deport you" and promised to cancel the student visas of "Hamas sympathizers."

- **Source:** EO: Additional Measures to Combat Anti-Semitism (Immigration Policy Tracking Project)
- **In the posts:** And then they came for me (2025-01-30); Operation “Wrath of Zion” (2025-01-31); Using AI to repress dissent (2025-03-07)

24. 2025-02-24

A civil trial in which Energy Transfer sought at least $300 million from Greenpeace over the 2016–2017 Dakota Access protests began with jury selection in Mandan, North Dakota, on February 24, 2025.

- **Source:** Greenpeace faces a $300 million lawsuit after Dakota Access Pipeline protests (NPR (via WUNC))
- **In the posts:** Protest Rights at Stake (2025-02-24)

25. 2025-03-04

On March 4, 2025, President Trump posted on Truth Social that "All Federal Funding will STOP" for any college, school or university that allows "illegal protests," adding that "agitators" would be imprisoned or sent back to their home countries.

- **Source:** Trump vows to stop federal funding for any school that allows 'illegal' protests (FOX 9)
- **In the posts:** Using AI to repress dissent (2025-03-07); Language (2025-03-13)

26. 2025-03-06

On March 6, 2025, Axios reported that the State Department was launching an AI-assisted "Catch and Revoke" effort, reviewing tens of thousands of student visa holders' social media accounts to revoke visas of those who appeared to support Hamas.

- **Source:** Scoop: State Dept. to use AI to revoke visas of foreign students who appear "pro-Hamas" (Axios); EO: Additional Measures to Combat Anti-Semitism (Immigration Policy Tracking Project)
- **In the posts:** Using AI to repress dissent (2025-03-07)

27. 2025-03-08 (corrected)

Mahmoud Khalil, a Palestinian activist and lawful permanent resident (green-card holder) who had been a Columbia University student negotiator, was arrested by immigration agents on March 8, 2025, held at the ICE processing center in Jena, Louisiana, and released on June 20, 2025 after 104 days on the order of U.S. District Judge Michael Farbiarz.

> ***Correction:*** *The 2025-03-13 post calls Khalil a 'permanent US citizen'; he is a lawful permanent resident, not a citizen.*

- **Source:** USA: Mahmoud Khalil released on bail (Amnesty International); Mahmoud Khalil released from ICE detention in Jena (KPLC)
- **In the posts:** Visualizing Peace (2025-03-12); Language (2025-03-13); Joint Task Force October 7 (2025-03-28); People’s Graduation (2025-05-25)

28. 2025-03-13

On the night of March 13, 2025, Department of Homeland Security agents with judicial warrants searched two Columbia University student residences; interim president Katrina Armstrong said no one was arrested and nothing was removed.

- **Source:** Update to Our Community Regarding DHS Activity Tonight (Columbia University Office of the President)
- **In the posts:** BREAKING: DHS enters Columbia dorms (2025-03-14)

29. 2025-03-25

Tufts University doctoral student Rumeysa Ozturk, a Turkish national on an F-1 visa, was detained by ICE in Somerville, Massachusetts on March 25, 2025 and taken to a detention center in Louisiana; her visa was revoked by the State Department, and she was released on May 9, 2025 by order of Judge William Sessions III.

- **Source:** Timeline of Rumeysa Ozturk's detention, subsequent activism and judicial proceedings (The Tufts Daily)
- **In the posts:** Pro-Palestinian solidarity Spring 2025 (2025-04-26)

30. 2025-06-06

Federal immigration agents arrested 44 people in operations across Los Angeles on June 6, 2025, prompting protests and clashes.

> ***Note:*** *Posts give June 6–7; the figure of 44 is for Friday, June 6.*

- **Source:** Federal authorities arrest dozens for immigration violations across Los Angeles (ABC7)
- **In the posts:** Presidential Authority & National Guard (2025-06-08)

31. 2025-06-07 (corrected)

Immigration raids in Los Angeles on June 6, 2025 set off days of protests; on June 7 President Trump signed a presidential memorandum federalizing at least 2,000 National Guard members under 10 U.S.C. 12406 to protect ICE operations, describing protests that inhibit federal law enforcement as "a form of rebellion," and California Governor Gavin Newsom objected and sued.

> ***Correction:*** *The 2025-06-08 post calls the June 7 directive a 'Presidential Executive Order'; it was a presidential memorandum.*

- **Source:** Department of Defense Security for the Protection of Department of Homeland Security Functions (memorandum, June 7, 2025) (U.S. Government Publishing Office); Maps and photos show how the Los Angeles ICE protests unfolded (CBS News)
- **In the posts:** Presidential Authority & National Guard (2025-06-08); Army in the Streets (2025-06-09)

32. 2025-06-10

About 700 active-duty U.S. Marines arrived in the Los Angeles area on June 10, 2025, and Mayor Karen Bass imposed an 8 p.m. to 6 a.m. curfew in downtown Los Angeles the same day.

- **Source:** Maps and photos show how the Los Angeles ICE protests unfolded (CBS News)
- **In the posts:** An Opportunity (2025-06-11)

33. 2025-06-14

On June 14, 2025, Minnesota state Rep. Melissa Hortman and her husband were killed and state Sen. John Hoffman and his wife were wounded in shootings that officials described as targeted political violence.

> ***Note:*** *Posts refer only to the killing of legislators.*

- **Source:** 2025 shootings of Minnesota legislators (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** The center cannot hold (2025-06-18)

34. 2025-12-04

The Department of Homeland Security's "Operation Metro Surge" immigration enforcement operation in the Twin Cities began on December 4, 2025; by late January 2026 a Justice Department attorney testified that at least 2,000 ICE officers and 1,000 Customs and Border Protection officers were taking part.

- **Source:** Operation Metro Surge (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Minneapolis Day of Prayer and Fasting (2026-01-22); Nomination of Minneapolis for Nobel Peace Prize (2026-02-03); Actively Object, Don’t Resist (2026-02-05)

35. 2026-01

During Operation Metro Surge, federal agents detained four members of the Oglala Sioux Tribe in a raid on a Minneapolis homeless encampment.

- **Source:** Operation Metro Surge (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Paradox of Indigenous Detentions (2026-02-04); Actively Object, Don’t Resist (2026-02-05)

36. 2026-01-07

Renee Nicole Good, a 37-year-old U.S. citizen, was shot and killed in her vehicle by an ICE agent in Minneapolis on January 7, 2026, during Operation Metro Surge.

- **Source:** Operation Metro Surge (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** It is time (2026-01-21); Minneapolis Day of Prayer and Fasting (2026-01-22); Actively Object, Don’t Resist (2026-02-05); A dozen Roses for Renee Good (2026-02-11)

37. 2026-01-23

On January 23, 2026, Minnesota organizers held "ICE Out of MN: Day of Truth and Freedom," a day of strike, prayer and marches against the federal enforcement surge, endorsed by more than a thousand labor unions and joined by tens of thousands of people.

- **Source:** Operation Metro Surge (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** It is time (2026-01-21); Minneapolis Day of Prayer and Fasting (2026-01-22)

38. 2026-01-24

Alex Pretti, a 37-year-old intensive care nurse at the Department of Veterans Affairs who was documenting federal enforcement actions, was shot and killed by U.S. Customs and Border Protection officers in Minneapolis on January 24, 2026.

- **Source:** Operation Metro Surge (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Nomination of Minneapolis for Nobel Peace Prize (2026-02-03); Actively Object, Don’t Resist (2026-02-05)

39. 2026-02

The editors of The Nation formally nominated the city of Minneapolis and its people for the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize for their nonviolent response to the federal immigration enforcement surge, and circulated a public petition in support.

- **Source:** Support the nomination of the City of Minneapolis and its people for the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize (The Nation (Action Network petition))
- **In the posts:** Nomination of Minneapolis for Nobel Peace Prize (2026-02-03)

Not yet verified

These statements appear in the posts but could not be checked against an outside source during this pass. They are not confirmed and not shown to be wrong.

- Of the $73 million Iowa companies received from ICE/CBP contracts (FY2008-2019), 69% came in 2017, and Rockwell Collins alone held 115 contracts worth $55 million. In the posts: Protest Against ICE in Iowa